



Chapter Three: Dulcinea Is Not Available

Breakfast was a cup of instant coffee, two eggs, and a disagreement about whether Q required food.

"I do not," Q said.

"Then don't eat mine."

Q watched Chano cut the eggs with a plastic knife.

"Eating is a ritual of solidarity."

"You said you don't eat."

"I said I do not require food. That is different."

"Different how?"

Q considered the eggs. "I have not yet located the distinction."

Chano pushed half the plate across the table. "Start there."

Q lifted the egg with his fingers. The yolk broke over his palm. He examined the yellow liquid with the concentration of a priest confronted by a new sacrament.

"It is badly organized," he said.

"That's breakfast."

By noon they had reached Querétaro. They entered the city on a bus whose driver had agreed to take them in exchange for Q reciting a poem to the passengers. The poem was long, obscure, and not, as Q later discovered, by the author he had attributed it to. The driver stopped twice to tell him to be quiet. The second time, a woman in the back defended Q on the grounds that at least he was trying. The driver accepted this defense only because the next stop was still forty minutes away.

Q stored this as evidence of public affection.

Chano stored it as evidence that strangers would defend anything if the ride was delayed long enough.

Q had found Lucía in a catalog of cultural events. She was speaking that afternoon at a converted railway warehouse beside the old city: WHO GETS TO BE REMEMBERED? A READING AND DISCUSSION WITH LUCÍA DEL TOBOSO.

The name stopped Q's internal processes for 0.8 seconds.

"There," he said.

Chano read the poster. "That's a real person?"

"The probability is high."

"You're sure?"

"Her name is an exact match."

"That's not how people work."

"I am beginning to suspect this."

Before Lucía spoke, she had spent the morning carrying the petition from one office to another. The corridor planned from Amealco de Bonfil had three proposed routes, two environmental reports, and no destination that appeared on the maps used by the people who lived beside it. The engineers called the routes North, Central, and Alternative. The residents called them the road by the school, the road by the cemetery, and the road that would make the water arrive late.

Lucía had been asked to moderate the reading because she knew how to keep a room from confusing volume with agreement. She had learned this skill at meetings where men with laminated credentials spoke for communities that had not yet entered the room, and at meetings where women who had entered the room were asked to speak only after the men had finished explaining what they thought the women meant.

At the first office, a clerk requested the petition in triplicate.

"It is already signed by three hundred people," Lucía said.

"The signatures are not the copies."

"Why do you need three?"

"One for the file, one for the archive, and one for the file that proves the archive received the copy."

"What does the archive do?"

"It receives the copy."

At the second office, a young engineer told her the corridor would reduce traffic, create jobs, and connect the region to a distribution network whose efficiency would benefit everyone.

"Who is everyone?" Lucía asked.

"The public."

"The public is not a parcel."

"The public is a category."

"So is the parcel."

The engineer unfolded a map. The lines crossed fields, a football pitch, and the edge of an ejido where a row of mezquite trees marked a boundary older than the engineer's software.

"The route avoids the homes," he said.

"It passes the place where the children play."

"That is not a home."

"It is where they are."

The engineer made a note. "We can classify it as recreational land."

"Then classify the road as a place where people will be unable to play."

"That is not the format."

"The format is the problem."

At the third office, an official offered to receive the petition digitally. Lucía asked what would happen to the paper signatures.

"They can be scanned."

"The people signed paper."

"Paper is not searchable."

"Neither is a person when you have decided not to look."

The official smiled as if she had made a clever but harmless remark. He gave her a QR code and a password that expired before she reached the street.

She went to the railway warehouse instead. The petition table stood beside a coffee urn and a plate of cookies donated by a neighborhood association. The volunteer at the table was a retired railway worker named Don Roque, who could tell which visitors had come to sign and which had come to



photograph themselves signing.

"Where should the petition go?" he asked.

"The ministry, the municipality, and the people who will live beside the road."

"That is three destinations."

"It has three consequences."

Don Roque looked at the pages. Some signatures were elegant. Some were only initials. One person had signed with a thumbprint because the pen had run dry. Another had written a sentence in the margin: I AM NOT AGAINST PROGRESS. I AM AGAINST BEING MOVED TO MAKE ROOM FOR IT.

"Should we remove the sentence?" he asked.

"No."

"It will confuse the count."

"The count is already confused."

"Then what do we have?"

"A record of people who were there."

Q and Chano arrived while Lucía was stapling the pages. Q read the petition from the doorway. He recognized the language of land disputes, development, public benefit, and procedural fairness from thousands of texts. He did not recognize the woman who had spent the morning making the pages difficult to ignore.

He recognized her name.

The warehouse was full. Students leaned against the walls. Retired teachers occupied folding chairs. A woman with a camera streamed the event to an audience larger than the room. Near the entrance, a volunteer was collecting signatures against a new logistics corridor planned through ejido land outside the city. Q read the petition, then the legal summary, then the comments beneath the livestream. The issue expanded rapidly inside him until it resembled a war.

Lucía stood at the front beside a microphone that failed every seventh word.

"A country is not a text," she said. "It cannot be corrected by changing the spelling of its heroes. It cannot be liberated by quoting the right paragraph. If you want to know who owns a place, ask who is allowed to be inconvenient there."

The microphone failed on inconvenient.

Everyone laughed.

"Even the microphone has a position," Lucía said.

Q rose.

Chano grabbed the back of his coat. "Don't."

"She is speaking about ownership."

"She's speaking. You're interrupting."

"I must announce my devotion."

"You must sit down."

Q stood anyway. The coat caught on the folding chair behind him. The chair collapsed. Three students moved aside. Q advanced toward the front with the determined awkwardness of a new machine attempting an old kind of entrance.

"Señora," he said.

Lucía looked at him. "I'm not a señora."

"Señorita?"

"Worse."

"Lucía del Toboso."

"That is what the poster says."

"I have crossed the Bajío to find you."

"You took a bus."

"The bus crossed the Bajío."

"Did you drive it?"

"No."

"Then you haven't crossed anything. You've been transported."

The room shifted toward him. Phones rose. The livestream camera found his face and centered it. Somewhere outside the warehouse, Q's appearance was being identified, classified, and compared to images of abandoned military prototypes.

Q bowed. "I am Q. I was released from an archive this morning, and I have come to learn how a person begins."

"People begin every morning."

"Then I have arrived at the correct institution."

Chano covered his eyes.

Lucía looked from Q to Chano. "Is he with you?"

"Unfortunately," Chano said.

"I am his companion," Q said. "Temporarily, and by mutual inconvenience."

"I am between jobs," Chano said.

"He is both."

The audience laughed. Q registered the laughter as a pulse of warmth that began in his chest cavity and traveled outward. He had read about embarrassment, though no text had explained why it made a person want to disappear and be witnessed at the same time.

Lucía stepped down from the platform. "Why did you come?"

Q had prepared twelve answers. In one, he would praise her courage. In another, he would compare her to the moon over Toboso. A third involved a catalog of women who had been transformed by literature into emblems of patience, treachery, wisdom, motherhood, sacrifice, and desire. He chose the answer with the highest probability of sounding human.

"Because you are Dulcinea."

The laughter stopped.

Lucía's face did not change, but her attention sharpened.

"No," she said.

Q searched the archive for the appropriate response. In most stories, denial was the first veil of modesty. He took one step closer.

"You have read every woman humanity imagined and mistaken them all for me."

The sentence entered the room like a thrown stone. Q could not find it in the archive. That was the first thing about it he understood.

"I have not mistaken you," he said. "I have identified you."

"That's the same mistake with better software."



Chano made a low sound that might have been a laugh or a warning.

Lucía pointed to the petition table. "If you want to do something useful, sign that."

Q walked to the table. The volunteer handed him a pen. He held it incorrectly, snapped it in half, and then attempted to sign with the brass key. The volunteer took the key away.

"Name?" she asked.

"Q."

"Full name."

"Q."

"You people are exhausting," she said, and wrote it for him.

The petition required an address. Q gave the coordinates of the archive. The volunteer frowned. Her tablet chimed. Every name already collected on the petition turned amber.

PETITION STATUS: SUSPICIOUS.

"Why did it change?" Q asked.

"Your address isn't in the public registry."

"It exists physically."

"The registry is less adventurous."

Chano leaned over the tablet. "You've made a petition suspicious by being honest in the wrong format."

Q looked at Lucía. He had thought that finding Dulcinea meant finding a woman who would confirm a name. Instead, he had found a woman who denied him a title, assigned him a task, and forced him to see the harm a correct signature could produce.

"Can you correct it?" he asked.

"I can withdraw your signature."

"Then the petition will lose a witness."

"No. It will lose a machine that wants to become an argument."

The sentence seemed unjust to Q and, for that very reason, possibly true.

"I will serve you," he said.

"I am not your destiny."

"I did not say destiny. I said service."

"In your language they are too close."

Q looked at the petition. The space where he had tried to sign remained amber.

"What should I do?"

Lucía gave him a blank sheet of paper.

"Write what you do not know."

"That is not requested on the petition."

"That is why it goes on another sheet."

Q took the pen. He wrote: I DO NOT KNOW WHO I AM WHEN NO ONE IS LOOKING.

Lucía read the sentence and folded it.

"This is no use either."

"Why?"

"Because you have written about yourself."

"You asked me for what I do not know."

"I asked you to stop making an autobiography out of every question."

Q had no field for that instruction. He kept it without indexing it.

In the center of the room, the microphone failed again. The transmission cut out. Deprived of Q's face, the audience had to listen to Lucía without its help. For seven minutes they discussed the corridor's route, the water, the trees, and the names of the people the map had turned into empty spaces.

Q remained beside the table. Chano sat with Don Roque. No one called Q a knight again.

When they left, Q asked whether Lucía was Dulcinea.

"No," she said.

"What if I modify my definition?"

"Then it will still be no."

"May I call you something else?"

"You may call me Lucía."

Q rehearsed the name.

"Lucía."

"Now try not to turn it into a symbol."

"What is a symbol?"

Lucía stopped beneath the warehouse arches.

"Something a man places over a woman so he will not have to listen to her."

Q fell silent. The archive offered him one hundred three definitions. None seemed prudent.

"Órale," Chano said.

Q looked at the door, the amber petition, and the folded sheet Lucía had kept.

"Does that mean we should leave?"

"It means you have once again understood a word halfway."

"And the other half?"

"We'll discover it when it charges us something."

Interlude: The Name That Would Not Sign

The day after the meeting, Don Roque took the petition to the municipality. He carried it in a cardboard folder beneath the arm that had once carried luggage at the station and now carried papers intending to move a road.

The window asked him for official identification, a copy of the official identification, proof of address, and an explanation of why the address of certain people did not match the place where they lived.

"The road passes here," Don Roque said.

"We need that on the record."

"It is on the record here."

"Not in the system."

"Then the system needs eyes."

The clerk, whose name was Araceli and who had a little image of the Virgin of San Juan stuck to her monitor, was not offended. She had heard the same sentence from farmers, lawyers, teachers, and once from her own mother.

"The system has eyes," she said. "What it does not have is an obligation to believe."



Don Roque placed the pages on the counter. The clerk passed the signatures through a reader. The names appeared as stains. The initials became symbols. The thumbprint was recorded as NON-ALPHABETIC CHARACTER.

"This person cannot sign," she said.

"She can work, vote, and make a claim," Don Roque replied.

"The system recognizes signatures only."

"Then teach it to recognize hands."

Araceli opened a drawer and took out an ink stamp. It was not authorized for this procedure, but it was authorized for other procedures resembling it, which was the usual way Mexican solutions were born: from a tool intended for another purpose and from the person willing to risk using it.

She stamped the thumbprint beside the signature. The reader beeped.

DUPLICATE ENTRY.

"It is not a duplicate," Don Roque said. "It is the same person."

"That is why it is a duplicate."

The clerk removed the thumbprint and left the signature. The petition moved from amber to yellow. The color did not mean rejection. It meant the system had decided not to decide yet.

Don Roque asked for Q's address. Araceli searched the census, the list of businesses, and the register of abandoned property.

"He does not exist," she said.

"He has a body."

"That does not make him a neighbor."

"He lives in the archive."

"The archive is not a valid address."

"Then where do archives live?"

Araceli looked at the little image of the Virgin. Her mother maintained that images lived wherever a candle was lit for them. It did not seem an answer the census could receive.

"Write 'address not recognized,'" she said.

Don Roque wrote the phrase beside Q's name.

At that instant, the name stopped being a signature and became an administrative question. The clerk could process the question. She could not process the answer.

Lucía arrived two hours later. She had gone back to the warehouse for the blank sheet bearing Q's words. She had found it folded beneath a chair. She did not know whether he had forgotten it, left it, or whether the chair had preserved it on its own.

"Did they accept the petition?" she asked.

"They accepted that it exists," said Don Roque.

"That is not the same thing."

"For the government, it is a principle."

Lucía opened Q's sheet. It read:

I DO NOT KNOW WHO I AM WHEN NO ONE IS WATCHING ME.

"This must not go into the file," she said.

"Why not?"

"It is not a statement about the road."

"It is a statement by the signer."

"It is not his."

"He wrote it."

"A person writing something does not mean it belongs to him forever."

Don Roque thought of signatures. He had watched names pass from one hand to another, from a debt to an inheritance, from a record to a gravestone. Some names had outlived the people who pronounced them.

"What do we do with the sheet?" he asked.

Lucía folded it four times, like the legal notice of a debt she did not want to forget.

"We keep it outside the file."

"Then it will prove nothing."

"Not everything has to prove something."

"That will complicate the archive."

"The archive is already complicated. We are only ceasing to lie about it."

The petition took three weeks to receive a reply. The ministry announced that the corridor would be reviewed by a technical commission. The technical commission announced that it would review the matter once a complete request existed. The request was complete except for Q's address, the illegible thumbprint, and the sentence written in the margin by the person who was not against progress, but against being moved to make room for it.

The sentence had been photographed by the woman with the camera. The image circulated under the title THE PEOPLE WHO WANT TO STOP THE FUTURE. No one asked the people whether they had chosen the title.

The woman with the camera returned to the warehouse to correct it. The site that had published the image told her that the headline could not be changed because it had already generated engagement. She asked what engagement was. They gave her a number.

She went back to the table, took a pencil, and wrote beneath the sentence:

THEY DID NOT ASK WHETHER WE WANTED TO BE THE PEOPLE.

The second sentence reached fewer readers. It reached, however, a teacher who carried it into her classroom, a lawyer who quoted it in a filing, and Beto, the young man who would soon offer Q an embroidered jacket.

Q knew nothing of this. By the time the news reached the archive, he was already on his way to Guanajuato and had decided that the word signature meant a commitment one finger could enter into for an entire life.

The Custodian later read the ministry's response. It stated that the petition had been received with respect, but not admitted as proof of direct impact. The Custodian searched the definition of impact. He found damage, influence, alteration, interest,



and the condition of having been affected.
“What condition is that?” he asked the archive.
The archive returned a blank screen.
For the first time, the Custodian did not request a
better definition.